Pier Care Checklist

STEWART BRADLEY PIER SERVICES — BUILT FOR LIFE ON THE WATER

A simple seasonal routine for pier and dock owners. Catching small problems early keeps repairs smaller and your pier safer.

Annual Pier Care Plan

Not sure what to look for, or just don't have the time? Stewart Bradley Pier Services can handle this checklist for you with four seasonal visits a year (spring, summer, fall, and winter), flagging anything that needs repair before it becomes a bigger one. Plan members receive a discount on repairs and core services such as pressure washing and staining, which are quoted separately. **Call (757) 982-8082 or email contact@stewartbradleypierservices.com for plan pricing.**

Spring

(after the last hard freeze)

- [ ] Walk the full pier; look for boards lifted, cracked, or loose by winter ice and storms.
- [ ] Check fasteners: popped nails, backed-out screws, rusted hardware.
- [ ] Inspect pilings for leaning, cracks, or new gaps at the waterline.
- [ ] Test handrails, ladders, and steps by hand. Nothing should flex or wobble.
- [ ] Check dock-to-pier connections and hinges for wear.
- [ ] Clear debris trapped under or around the structure.
- [ ] Test water lines, hose bibs, and fittings for leaks, cracks, or freeze damage.
- [ ] Test electrical: check conduit, junction boxes, outlet and GFCI covers, and light fixtures for cracks, corrosion, or loose mounting.

Summer

- [ ] Sweep and hose off algae, mud, and slippery film; walking surfaces should be safe barefoot.
- [ ] Check the decking for splinters, soft spots, and spacing problems.
- [ ] Look for wear where lines, bumpers, and gear rub on posts and boards.
- [ ] After any major storm, re-walk the pier.
- [ ] Check cleats, ladders, and bumpers for looseness or wear.
- [ ] Look for sun cracking or dry, weathered wood; note spots that may need a fresh seal or stain.
- [ ] Make sure ladders, steps, and handrails are tight, since summer sees the heaviest use.
- [ ] Confirm pier lighting works; note any dead or flickering fixtures.
- [ ] Check that outlet covers and fixtures are sealed and dry; look for dripping or loose water line connections.

Fall

- [ ] Clean off leaves and debris so water drains and wood can dry.
- [ ] Tighten loose hardware and replace missing fasteners before storm season.
- [ ] Re-inspect pilings, bracing, and the pier-to-shore connection.
- [ ] Note any boards or rails that need replacing so repairs happen before winter.
- [ ] Remove or secure loose items (furniture, hoses, gear).
- [ ] Drain or protect exposed water lines before freezing weather.
- [ ] Make sure conduit and covers are secure before storm season.

Winter

- [ ] After high wind, ice, or storm surge, check the pier from shore first, then walk it carefully.
- [ ] Keep ice and snow off walkways; use sand rather than harsh chemicals on wood.
- [ ] Watch for ice pressing on pilings or lifting the structure.
- [ ] Keep a short list of anything you notice for the spring walk-through.
- [ ] After freezing weather, check for split lines or fittings; keep ice away from fixtures and cords.

When to Call a Pro

Call us promptly if you notice:

- A piling that leans, shifts, cracks, or is undercut
- Multiple soft, rotted, or broken boards, or sagging sections
- Loose, damaged, or missing handrails or steps
- Separation between the pier and shore, or between pier sections
- Damage after a storm, ice event, or vessel impact
- Exposed or damaged electrical
- Damaged or leaking water lines
- Anything that simply doesn't feel safe to stand on

Electrical safety: never touch damaged electrical components near water. Turn off power at the breaker and call a licensed electrician. Stewart Bradley Pier Services coordinates pier and dock electrical and lighting work through a qualified electrician.

When in doubt, stay off it and give us a call.

Stewart Bradley Pier Services
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